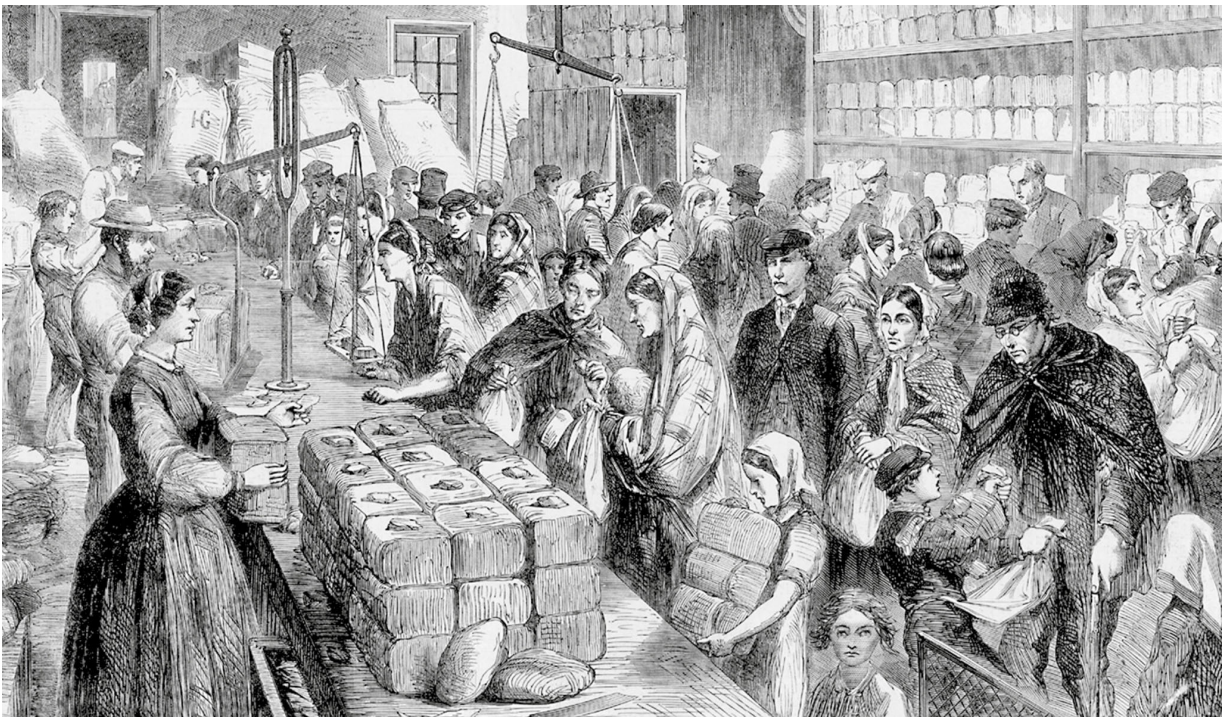


government did not want to risk war and years of poor relations with the United States for the sake of the South's cause, until it could show its independence to be imminent and inevitable.

Britain declared neutrality, granting the Confederacy belligerent status in international law, on May 13, 1861, but this was more of a practical response to the situation than a strong desire to intervene on the side of the South. The South's new status gave Southern agents important benefits, such as the ability to buy arms, and it also legalized Confederate attacks on Union merchant shipping. These attacks would prove devastating to the Union fleet.



Cotton famine

The break in the South's cotton exports had a devastating effect on England's mill workers. With no raw fiber to process, their jobs did not exist. Unable to work, they relied on various charities for cheap food.

Relations with Britain

Northerners took great offense at the British declaration, but from the European perspective, the Confederacy had obviously created a government that deserved this level of international recognition. The Union declaration of a blockade represented a tacit recognition that the Confederacy was more than just a small band of rebels.